One method of sidelining populists' constituents is to actively shift the domestic balance of power in favor of nonpopulist groups. IOs can amplify the voices of nonpopulists or incentivize voters to support nonpopulist leaders by offering tangible benefits. For example, the European Union presented Polish voters with a stark choice, promising significant agricultural subsidies if a nonpopulist government were elected (Csehi and Zgut 2021). These strategies aim to marginalize populist leaders by reducing their domestic appeal and creating incentives for citizens to back alternative political figures.

Another tactic is to circumvent populists' constituents by engaging in covert interactions with populist leaders. Leaders often face electoral punishment for inconsistencies between their rhetoric and actions (Tomz 2007). Publicly criticizing IOs while privately cooperating with them can damage populists' credibility. To avoid this, IOs can offer secure, confidential avenues for communication and negotiation. For instance, the IMF uses private discussions at executive board meetings, where states' submissions are archived and kept secret for five to seven years before being released to the public (Carnegie, Clark, and Kaya 2024). Such measures allow populists to engage constructively without risking domestic backlash.

Similarly, IOs can handle rule violations discretely, opting not to publicize infractions. Institutions like the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) and the WTO often discover violations but carefully weigh whether to disclose them. Public exposure might enforce norms but could also provoke backlash among populists' constituents, who often view IOs as illegitimate constraints on sovereignty. By addressing violations privately, IOs can preserve relations with populists while avoiding inflaming anti-IO sentiment.

Examples of covert interactions abound in the international system. The WTO historically conducted private negotiations in its "green room," while the Bank for International Settlements has long operated under a veil of secrecy (Carnegie and Carson 2020). Similarly, the IMF's approach to behind-the-scenes communication enables sensitive discussions without risking public fallout.

However, sidelining populists' constituents can also have downsides. If populists oppose IOs for ideological reasons, rather than because of